The Forsyth County News

Opinion

This is a page of opinions – ours, yours and others. Signed columns and cartoons are the opinions of the writers and artists and may not reflect our views.

Get informed about issues and let the dialogue begin

Newspapers are involved in the information business. From a community newspaper's standpoint, an informed community is a better community because it is generally the informed who are involved.

The Forsyth County community is continuing on its growth pattern and, because of that growth, some individuals maintain the county needs to move to the next level in addressing the "growing pains" being experienced by Cumming and Forsyth County.

One area for moving ahead is water. The contract talks between the County Commission and Cumming officials related to the county obtaining water from the city to expand the availability to water supplies across the county is one example.

Another suggested area for forward motion is wastewater treatment. With growth, residential development and commercial and industrial development, the need for sewerage enhancements is being stressed. Septic tanks are not suitable for some development and proliferation of septic tanks in small-lot developments generate concerns. This is one area addressed in the Master Land Use Plan draft which is the subject of upcoming community meetings which begin on Tuesday. (See related story on Page 1A).

Yet another segment of government offered for possible change to better serve the growing population – both residential and business – is law enforcement. Creation of a county-wide police department is being offered by the Forsyth County Board of Commissioners as a July 21 referendum issue.

Because there has been little discussion about the issue of a county-wide police force to date, the *Forsyth County News* has been presenting different perspectives of law enforcement organization related by individuals who have been part of some of the changes which have occurred in other communities.

The information is being offered to provide a launching pad for discussion and to open communication in the community about the issue which will be at hand. Dialogue on such an issue – any issue which has the potential of making significant change which citizens need to understand – is vital.

That is why we are offering information about the workings of law enforcement operations in surrounding counties and other communities which have experienced similar or strikingly different decisions. It is important to look beyond your geographic borders in search of knowledge if you are to avoid reinventing a wheel which fails to meet your transportation needs.

If we look, learn and discuss issues, the answers will hopefully be arrived at more responsibly. Let's seek out information and let the dialogue begin.

What do YOU think?

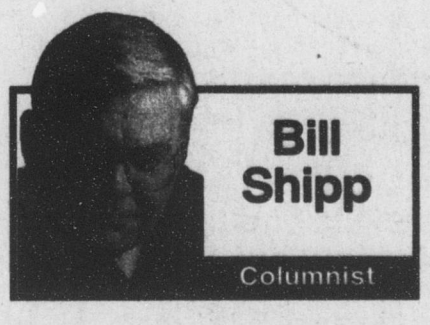
... about the Board of Commissioners' call for a referendum on the issue of a County Police Department? Do you plan to participate in the proposed July 21 referendum? Will you vote Yes or No or are you undecided?

Mail your response to:

THE FORSYTH COUNTY NEWS
P. O. Box 210
Cumming, GA 30028



The rehabilitation of Newt Gingrich



Newt Gingrich hoped for an election fight, preferably against a Democrat. He needed the battle to re-establish his credentials as champion of conservative Republicans. And to galvanize his nationwide fund-raising apparatus.

The U.S. House speaker wanted a challenge so badly that he even wrote a letter to University System Chancellor Stephen Portch. He pleaded with Portch to overturn an order restricting Professor Christina Jeffrey's right to run against him. Alas, Chancellor Portch said no, and so did the U.S. district court. Professor Jeffrey said she would appeal. But her hopes for mounting a worthwhile anti-Newt campaign appear dim at best. As dawn broke on the final day of qualifying for candidates in the 1998 election, Gingrich was without an opponent — Democrat or fellow Republican — for the first time in his 20-year career in the House. If one showed up at the last moment, he/she would likely be a fringe challenger with no hope of making a dent in the speaker's bandwagon.

Gingrich has finally reached the mountaintop of elective politics. No one wants to take him on. He seems a bit bewildered at the prospect of not having to wage another biennial fight for his political life. In the past, Gingrich was a lightning rod for challenges. Often a fire-breathing partisan, the congressman attracted a series of adversaries from the state Democratic establishment in his old district south of Atlanta. He vanquished each, usually by narrow margins. In his current district in the northern suburbs, Gingrich has drawn fire from the political right and left. In recent months, Gingrich's fellow Republicans have been especially unhappy with the speaker.

He appeared too cozy with President Clinton and sidestepped discussion of possible impeachment. He aligned himself with the administration on statehood for Puerto Rico and other perceived liberal issues. Back in the district, his former buddies in the GOP's conservative ranks muttered angrily about betrayal and jumping ship on the Republican revolution.

Then out of the blue came The New Newt. He got a fresh hairdo and a more expensive suit, and made a slow U-turn on the White House. He suggested that Clinton come clean about his relationship with Monica Lewinsky, that the president tell the truth about Whitewater. Compared to other attacks on Clinton, Gingrich's criticism was pale stuff.

Even so, the White House spin team immediately spun into action, demanding that Gingrich "come to his senses" and even "get back on his medication."

Gingrich could not have scripted a better scenario going into the election season. The zealous defenders of Clinton gave Gingrich just what he needed: an unrestrained barrage of brickbats from the left. Complaints about Gingrich's recent Milquetoast performances dried up. Capable Republican challengers fell silent.

But Professor Jeffrey, a member of the political science faculty at Kennesaw State University, was insistent on running as a Democrat against Gingrich.

After all, she had a personal score to settle. Gingrich had fired her as House historian after Democrats dug up from an academic course old comments of hers that sounded vaguely pro-Nazi. Jeffrey's name was finally cleared of the attempted smear. Yet Gingrich declined to reinstate her.

When the University System required she take an unpaid leave of absence to run for Congress or anything else, Gingrich intervened on her behalf.

Perhaps he remembered his own days as a college professor/candidate when his superiors frowned on his repeated challenges to an entrenched and influential Democratic congressman, Jack Flynt. Whatever the reason, the speaker wrote Portch: "The Rule [requiring a candidate to take unpaid leave] is particularly disturbing because it has the greatest impact on individuals who are not independently wealthy and are therefore unable to afford to leave their jobs in order to run for office. There are many fine people currently teaching in the university system who I believe are unfairly prohibited from the right to run for office."

Gingrich made a valid point and performed a gallant deed. And the White House is trashing him again. His poll numbers, especially among conservatives, are likely to rise to new highs. Newt is back in the catbird's seat. A Gingrich bid for the presidency in 2000 doesn't seem quite so absurd after all

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Letters

Reader offers support for tree ordinance

DEAR EDITOR:

In this Sunday's paper, I read about the "tree ordinance's" support and opposition: I am writing to fully support any ordinance and/or law that promotes communities and neighborhoods with trees - big, old, beautiful trees that have been there on the land for many, many years.

My husband and I have lived in Cumming for a long time and we looked long and hard for a home and yard with many trees; for shade, wild birds, and beauty for our family to enjoy.

I understand that developers have decisions to be made on economy, but I have seen so many sad, treeless "parking lots" (much like most subdivisions) be built in Cumming within the past few years. Please, to all of the local people with the power to make these decisions whether a tree is preserved or bulldozed: think of, and promote, the appeal, beauty, and necessity of trees in our community.

Allison Barkley
Cumming

Sheriff Hendrix replies to resident's concerns

DEAR EDITOR:

A letter appeared in your Sunday, April 26 issue written by the aunt of Levi Frady, the 11 year-old Forsyth County boy whose body was found in Dawson Forest in October. I wanted to address some concerns she raised in this letter.

First of all, I want to assure Ms. Patrick and all of the relatives and friends of this child that the Sheriff's Office is doing everything humanly possible to apprehend the person or persons responsible for his murder. Although Levi Frady did live in Forsyth County, the crime of murder did occur in Dawson County. Under the law, a crime must be investigated by the county authorities in the county where it occurred. When more than one county is involved in a crime, a common practice in law enforcement is to ask for assistance from a larger agency. That agency in this case is the Georgia Bureau of Investigation (G.B.I.). The G.B.I. is now the lead investigating agency, with Dawson County assisting. The Forsyth County Sheriff's Office is only a support agency in this investigation, unlike the investigation of the decapitated man. In that case, we were the lead investigating agency. At the beginning of the investigation, all of the evidence was located in Forsyth County.

We now have an investigator who is working with the G.B.I. on a full-time basis, following up on leads given to him The G.B.I. and Dawson County authorities are also very concerned about the murder of this child and have done a professional job with the investigation.

Also in this letter, mention was made of the disagreements between the County Commission and the Sheriff taking time away from this investigation. The Commissioners have been nothing but supportive throughout the investigation. They contributed money towards a reward fund and Chairman Bill Jenkins has also verbally given me permission to use whatever overtime hours we may need to solve this horrible crime. In no way has any disagreement between the Commissioners and the Sheriff hampered the investigation of the murder of Levi Frady.

The death of Levi Frady never leaves my mind. Unfortunately, there are no deadlines on investigations. Many times crimes are solved only when the perpetrator's conscious begins to wear down and he or she must tell someone to alleviate themselves of the heavy burden of guilt.

I promise we will continue to work diligently to solve this murder. One day someone will be brought to justice and pay for the crime that has been committed against one of God's children.

Denny Hendrix
Sheriff, Forsyth County

Forsyth County News letter policy

The *Forsyth County News* welcomes your opinions on issues of public concern. Letters must be signed and include full address and a daytime and evening phone number for verification. Names and hometowns of letter writers will be included for publication, without exception. Telephone numbers will not be published. Letters should be limited to 350 words and may be edited or condensed. The same writer or group may only submit one letter per month for consideration. Letters must be submitted by noon Wednesday for Sunday publication. We do not publish poetry or blanket letters, and generally do not publish letters concerning consumer complaints. Unsigned or incorrectly identified letters will be withheld. Mail letters to the *Forsyth County News*, P. O. Box 210, Cumming, Ga 30028, hand deliver to 302 Old Buford Road, or fax to (770) 889-6017.

State official restates referendum limits

DEAR EDITOR:

In the wake of several telephone calls from Forsyth County citizens upset over today's article entitled "State ethics board patrols the 'fine line' in referendums," some clarification is appropriate.

One of the objectives of the Ethics in Government Act is to promote fair elections by requiring the disclosure of money contributed and expended and disclosure of financial activity by groups opposing or promoting the passage of a ballot question in a local referendum.

The law prohibits agencies of government or anyone acting on behalf o such an agency from making, directly or indirectly any contribution to any political action committee, political organization, campaign committee or to any candidate. this prohibition bars the use of taxpayer funds, or other government resources to influence any matter to be voted on by citizens.

Political activity of individuals on their personal time and other personal resources is generally an exercise of political free speech protected by the Bill of Rights. Unfortunately the use of terms like "fine line" and "gray area" cause people to be fearful about participating in the election process.

The goal of the State Ethics Commission is to prevent complaints. By informing citizens of legal requirements so no one violates the law unintentionally, most problems can be avoided.

C. Theodore Lee
Executive Secretary
State Ethics Commission

Chamber not opposed to new tree ordinance

DEAR EDITOR:

The Chamber is NOT opposed to the proposed Tree Ordinance. When your new [news editor] called me I told him that the Chamber had not developed a position on the proposed ordinance. I was invited by Gretchen Dukes, Planner, to sit in on a review of the ordinance. After listening to the comments of those present, I told your reporter that I would feel certain the Board of the Chamber would endorse the concept

See *LETTERS*, Page 15A